January 28, 1959

I left the group today. I told them I wasn't feeling well and that it would be better if I went back, they tried to persuade me, but I didn't want to slow them down. Saying goodbye was harder than I imagined. Everyone was joking and light as ever; I felt out of step with their laughter. The trip had been wonderful until now. The mountains were endless, the air so clean it almost stung, and the nights around the fire made me feel like I belonged somewhere. Everyone was kind in their own way, laughing, teasing, helping one another, although Semyon seemed a bit off lately. He barely joined the conversations, always quiet, like his thoughts were elsewhere. I thought maybe he was just tired. It felt strange watching them walk away. Their figures grew smaller against the snow until they were gone, and I suddenly felt how empty the mountains could be. I kept thinking about the last few days, Lyudmila throwing snow at Georgiy, Igor trying to fix the tent poles while laughing at himself, Zina humming a song I didn't know. It all feels very far away now. I hope they make it to the pass and come back with stories to tell. I'll miss their noise, the warmth, the way it felt like a family for a while. The quiet tonight feels heavier than usual.

Yuri